CoinDesk

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The Definitive Stablecoin Landscape Series

NORTH AMERICA



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Table of Contents

I. Market Overview: North American Stablecoin Landscape

II. Regulatory Environment

III. Stablecoin Use Cases in North America

IV. Liquidity, Markets, and Technical Infrastructure

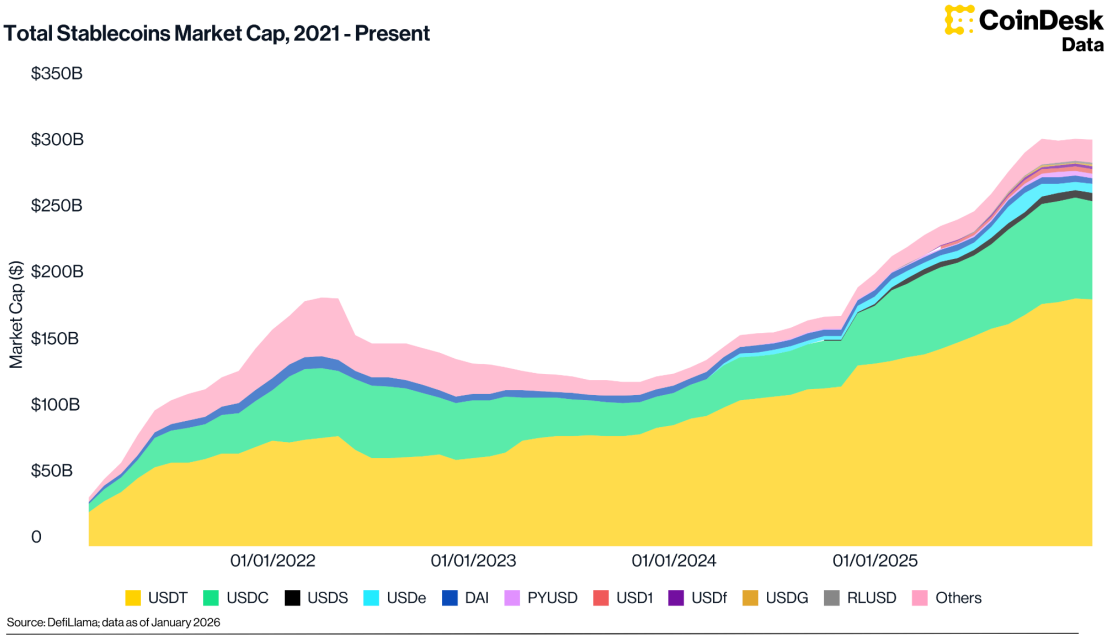
V. RLUSD: A Case Study Inside the North American Stablecoin Market

VI. Why RLUSD Fits North American Market Needs

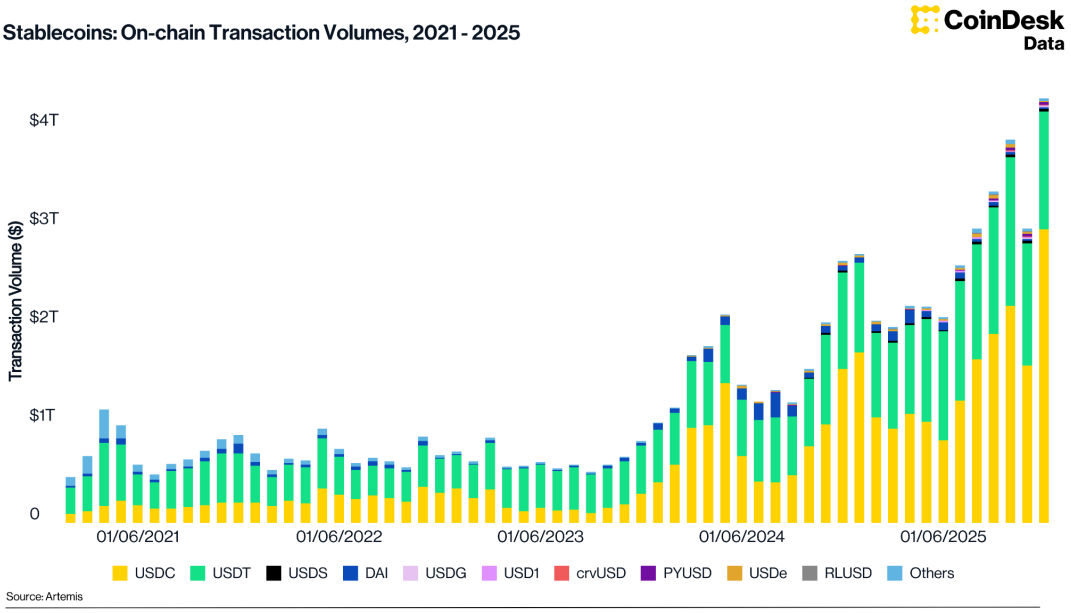
VII. Strategic Outlook for Stablecoins in North America (Next 2-3 Quarters)

VIII. Conclusion

Market Overview: North American Stablecoin Landscape

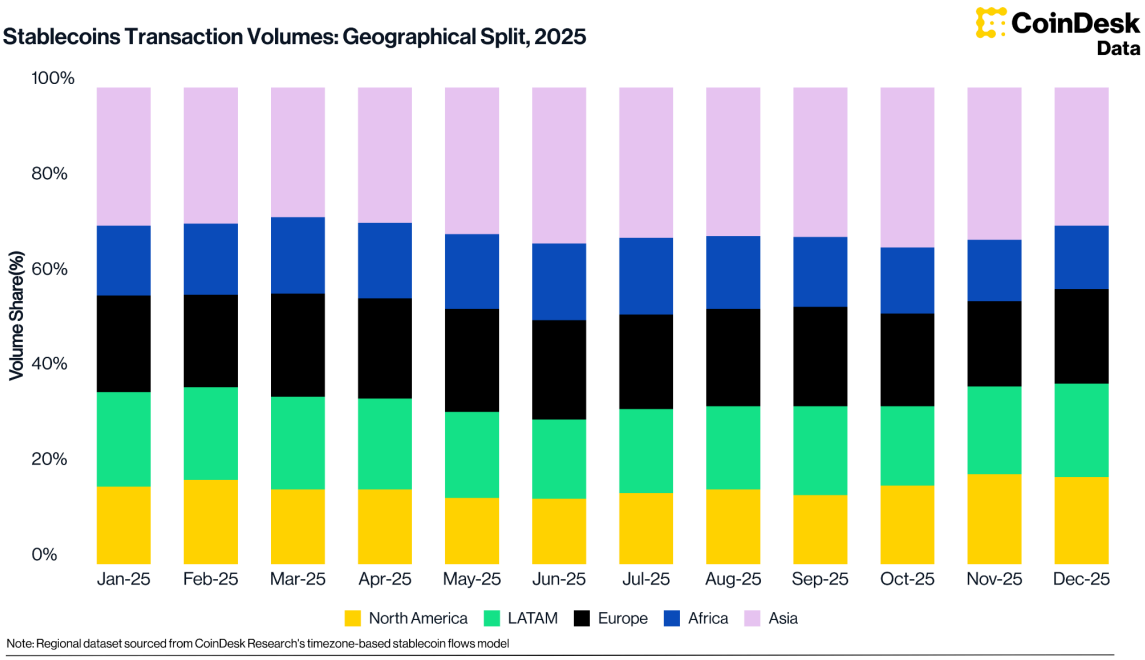


2025 was a watershed year for the stablecoin sector. Total market capitalization rose 50% to reach $308B - adding $102B in net supply over the year - the largest annual increase in dollar terms since 2021. Once used predominantly for crypto trading on centralized exchanges and DeFi applications, stablecoins have since evolved into a core payments infrastructure, increasingly underpinning cross-border remittances, on-chain settlement, and real-world transaction flows.



On-chain transaction volume using stablecoins has surged by 74% to $33.4T in 2025 with December marking a new record for monthly transaction volumes. USDC leads other stablecoins in on-chain transactions with a market share of 54.8%, followed by USDT accounting for 39.8%.

With 99% of the total market cap denominated in USD, North America remains the primary engine driving stablecoin adoption with the many of the largest issuers - Circle, Paxos, Ripple and PayPal - all headquartered in the United States. In 2025, the region settled $5.32T in volume, representing 16.1% of global stablecoin activity. Crucially, this means over 80% of transactions occurred outside North America - underscoring the 'export economy' of the digital dollar and its status as the world's preferred reserve asset.



Stablecoin activity in North America is heavily institutionally driven. A recent paper from the International Monetary Fund (IMF) finds that North American stablecoin transfers have the highest average transaction size globally, at $35,016, pointing to the outsized role of larger, more sophisticated participants. This pattern aligns with broader on-chain evidence from Chainalysis, which shows that North America leads globally in high-value crypto activity overall, with 45% of total transaction value occurring in transfers exceeding $10 million - underscoring the region's concentration of institutional-scale flows beyond stablecoins alone.

While the use cases for stablecoins have expanded beyond trading into payments and cross-border remittances, activity remains predominantly driven by crypto native use cases - namely trading on centralized exchange (CEX) and engaging with DeFi applications. This persistence reflects the market's historical evolution, shaped by two prior structural phases that entrenched stablecoins within crypto-native financial infrastructure.

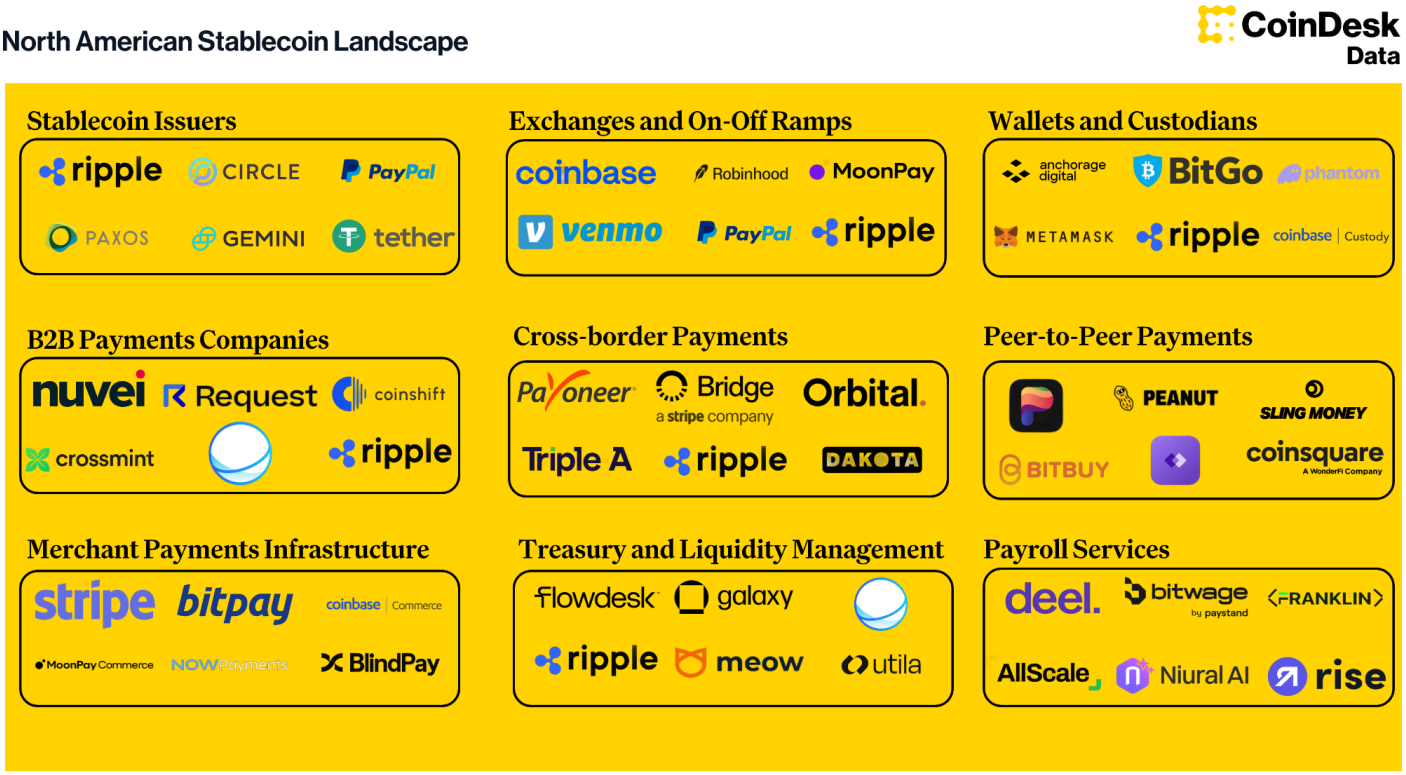
During the first phase - the trading infrastructure era (2015-2020) - stablecoins functioned primarily as fiat proxies on crypto exchanges. They enabled liquidity across trading pairs and facilitated price discovery, with growth largely fueled by retail speculation and minimal institutional participation.

The second phase (2020 - 2024) - financialization era saw stablecoins evolve into productive on-chain assets. They became the dominant form of collateral across lending protocols, decentralized exchanges, and yield strategies, embedding themselves deeply within DeFi's core primitives and driving sustained demand.

The market has entered a third phase of development: the institutionalization era. In this phase, stablecoins are increasingly functioning as programmable payment rails for fintechs and enterprises rather than purely crypto-native instruments. Over the past two years, the emergence of tokenized Treasury bills has introduced yield-bearing alternatives that rival - and in some cases exceed - DeFi-native returns, accelerating adoption among corporate treasuries. This shift has been reinforced by greater regulatory clarity and the growing participation of traditional financial institutions and Web2 firms. Collectively, these trends mark a transition from crypto-native use cases toward deeper integration with the global financial system.

As a result, North America has become the most strategically important region for global stablecoin adoption - with leadership in regulatory clarity, financial infrastructure, custody solutions, and institutional distribution channels. While USDT remains the dominant global liquidity token with a market dominance of 60.8%, North-America's emphasis is heavily skewed toward compliant, transparently- backed stablecoins such as USDC, PYUSD, and RLUSD.

North America Stablecoin Ecosystem Landscape

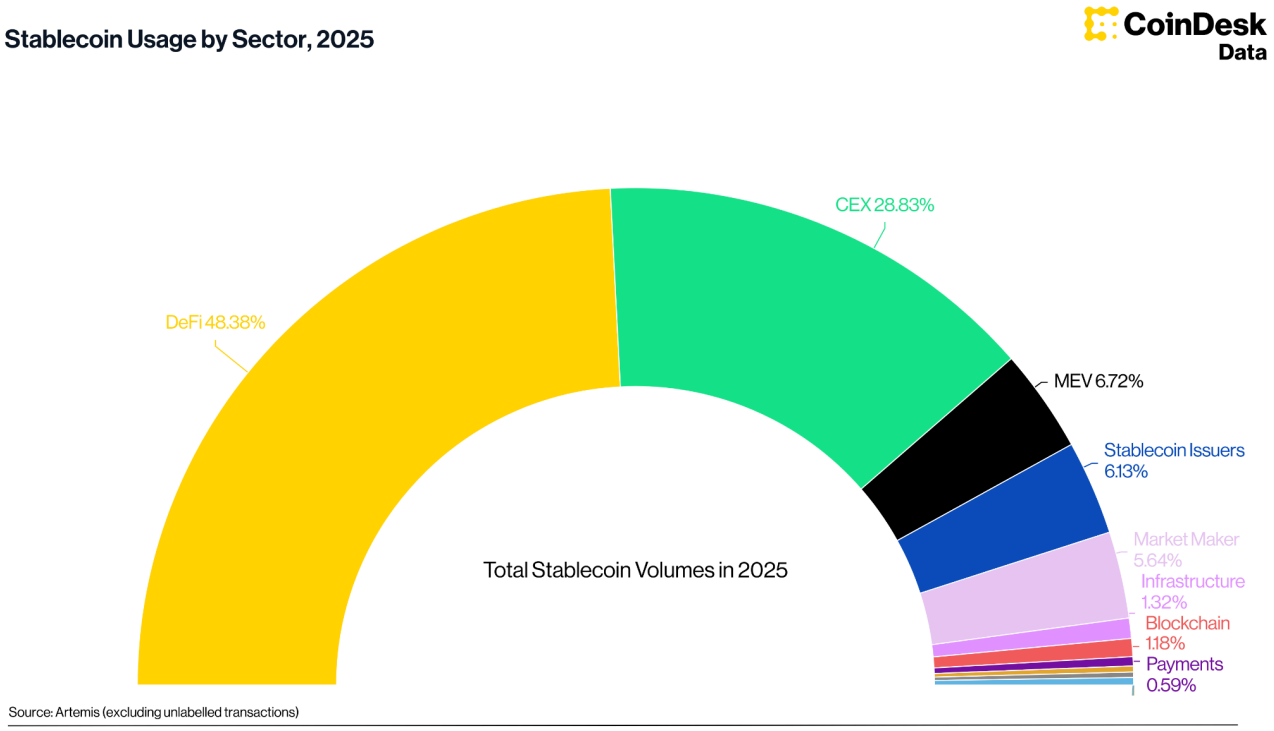


Note: The list is not exhaustive

In 2026, the infrastructure underpinning the movement of money has evolved into four distinct lanes, each serving a specific function within the digital financial ecosystem:

Centralized Finance (CeFi):
Centralized exchanges and fintech platforms - such as PayPal and Venmo - continue to serve as the primary on-ramps for retail users and small businesses accessing stablecoins. These platforms provide familiar interfaces, regulatory coverage, and integrated fiat rails that lower barriers to adoption. According to Artemis, approximately 24.2% of total stablecoin supply was held on centralized exchanges as of the end of 2025, underscoring their continued importance in stablecoin distribution and liquidity.

Decentralized Finance (DeFi):
DeFi has emerged as a core venue for yield generation, particularly among North American institutional funds. From a usage perspective, DeFi accounts for 48.4% of stablecoin activity, underscoring the central role stablecoins play across on-chain financial applications and decentralized market infrastructure. Rather than holding idle cash in low-yield bank accounts, institutions deploy USDC into DeFi protocols such as Aave and Sky to access tokenized U.S. Treasury yields, typically in the 4-5% range.



Over-the-Counter (OTC) Markets:
OTC desks such as Galaxy Digital Trading, Ripple Prime, Coinbase Prime, and Cumberland facilitate some of the largest stablecoin flows in North America. These venues are favored by corporate treasurers and institutional participants executing large-scale liquidity movements that would otherwise create market impact on public exchanges.

Payment Corridors:
Payment corridors represent the fastest-growing use case for stablecoins in 2026, driven by both domestic and cross-border settlement efficiencies.

- **B2B Settlements:** Large corporates, including Walmart and Amazon, are steadily exploring the possible use of stablecoins for vendor payments to avoid multi-day ACH settlement delays. According to Artemis data, B2B payments represent the largest stablecoin payment category by volume, accounting for 62.9% of total activity as of the end of 2025.

- **Cross-border Remittances:** Stablecoin-based remittances now account for a meaningful share of cross-border flows, enabling near-instant settlement at fees below $1.00, compared to traditional banking fees that can exceed 6%.

While numerous stablecoins exist, the North American market is highly concentrated around a small number of issuers:

Circle - USDC (Market Cap: $78.7B*)

Circle has the strongest penetration across U.S regulated exchanges. It has the highest institutional adoption, driven by its regulatory first approach with monthly attestations, transparent reserves, established banking relationships and proven operational competency.

Tether - USDT (Market Cap: $184B*), USAT (Market Cap: $27.7M*)

USDT dominates offshore liquidity and has the highest volume in Asia and LATAM. It has limited institutional penetration in North America due to its regulatory positioning. In 2025, Tether announced USAT as an alternative to USDT, positioning itself as a regulated stablecoin, aimed at expanding its presence in the American market.

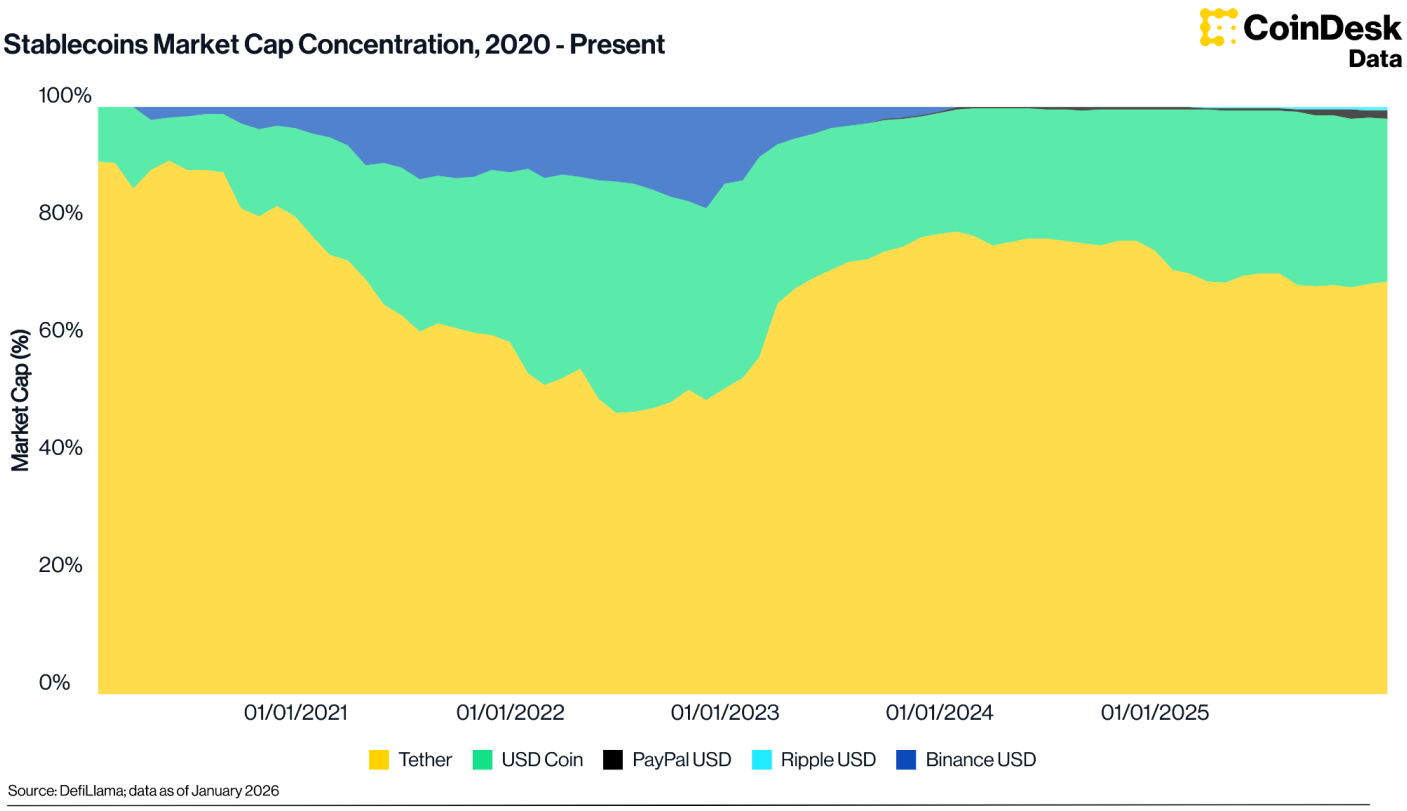
Ripple - RLUSD (Market Cap: $1.43B*)

RLUSD is a stablecoin designed for enterprise use cases including payments and capital markets businesses, as well as the emerging ecosystem on the XRP Ledger. It is composed of high quality liquid assets, cash and cash equivalents, in accordance with the NYDFS Guidance on the Issuance of U.S Dollar-Backed stablecoins.

PayPal - PYUSD (Market Cap: $4.00B*)

With native integrations into PayPal and Venmo, PayPal's reach to 400M+ users gives it unique distribution advantages. Backed by Paxos Trust, PYUSD is positioned to bring stablecoins into mainstream consumer payments.

** Market cap data is as of 25th Mar 2026*

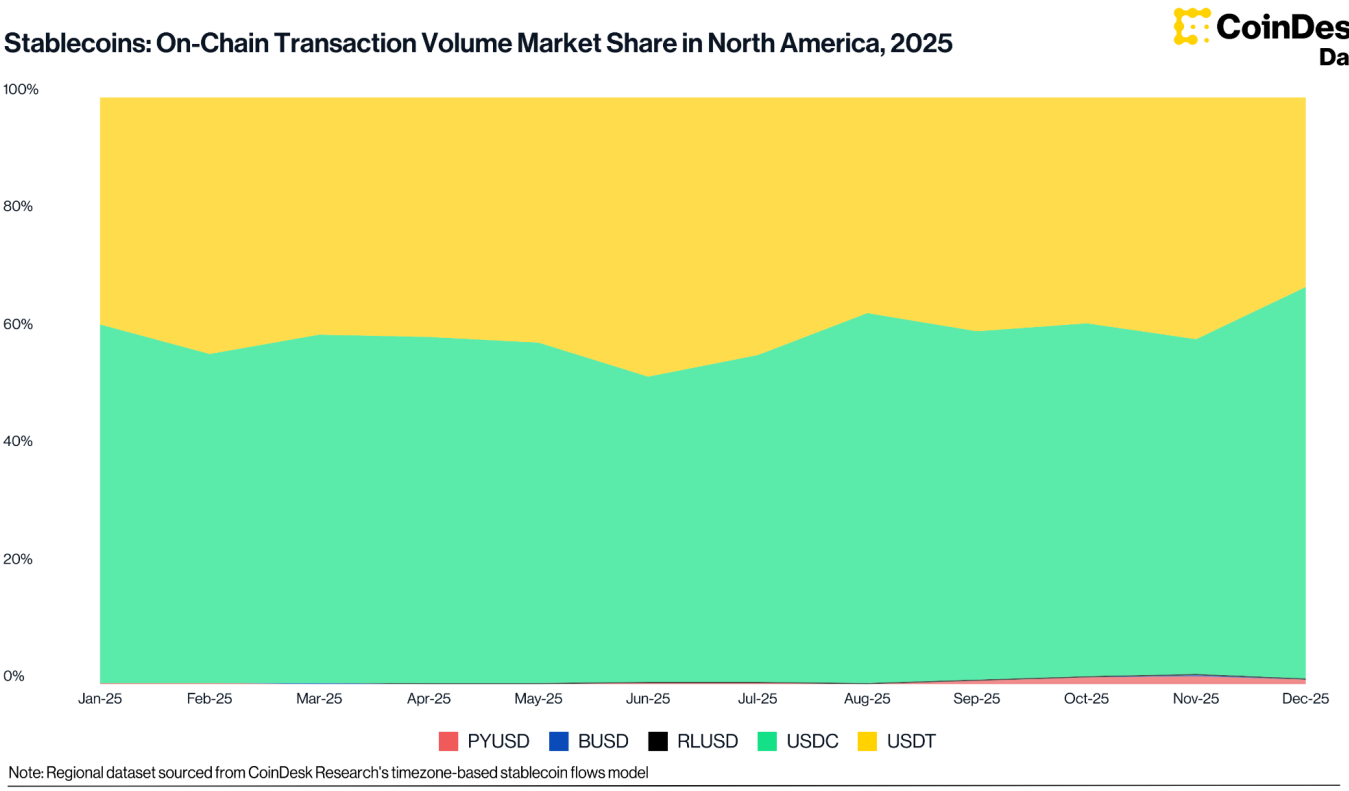


Historically, USDT dominated the stablecoin landscape, accounting for more than 80% of total market share at the beginning of 2020. This dominance was driven by USDT's deep integration across centralized exchanges, where it became the primary trading pair and settlement asset as many platforms were unable to offer direct USD access. As a result, USDT played a central role in capital preservation and liquidity management during periods of heightened volatility in digital asset markets.

The subsequent expansion of DeFi catalyzed demand for alternative stablecoins, most notably USDC, which saw its market share climb to a peak of 35.8% in 2022. Over the same period, Binance USD (BUSD) gained significant traction, reaching a market share of 15.8%, broadly mirroring Binance's own peak market dominance. However following Paxos' decision to halt BUSD issuance after receiving a Wells Notice from the SEC, USDT regained momentum, with its market share rising to 71.1% by the start of 2024.

More recently, the ongoing institutionalization era has driven increased demand for regulated stablecoins relative to offshore alternatives. As a result, USDC's market share rose to 25.2% in 2025, alongside the emergence of new institutional entrants such as PayPal's PYUSD and Ripple's RLUSD, both of which have entered the top 10 stablecoins by market capitalization in 2025.

Underscoring this trend, USDC's market share on North American centralized exchanges has increased sharply to 45.9%, from 20.0% at the start of the year. Similarly, USDC dominates on-chain transaction volumes in the North American region - with a market share of 66.6% - highlighting the popularity and demand for USDC and other regulated stablecoins.

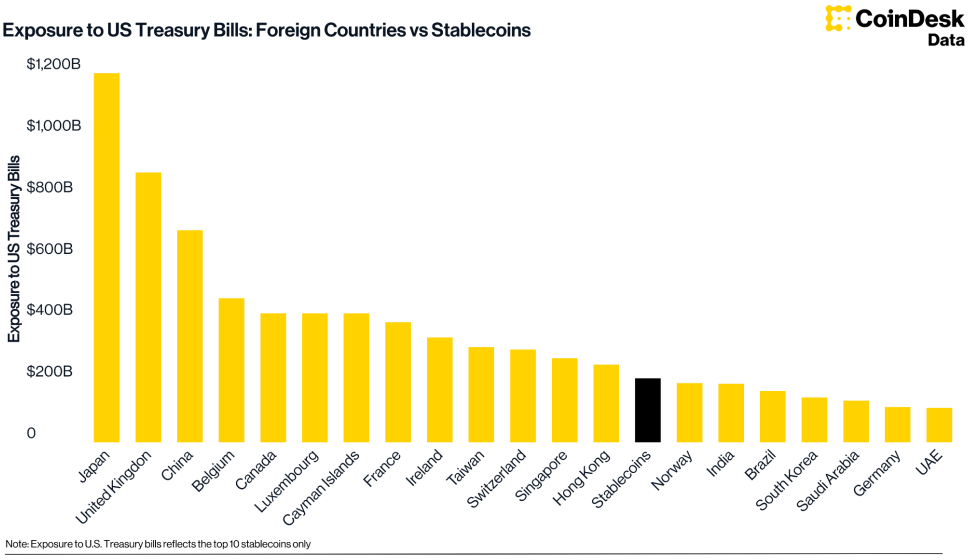


This highlights the macro shift in North America with a rising trend towards onshore, regulated, fiat-backed stablecoins. This shift is driven by factors such as: regulatory pressure on exchanges and fintechs to use compliant assets, institutional mandates that prohibit exposure to offshore or opaque issuers, treasury and payment use cases requiring bank-grade transparency, consumer protection requirements in U.S and Canadian jurisdictions.

This shift mirrors historical financial cycles where liquidity initially grew in unregulated environments, but institutional capital concludes the cycle by migrating to regulated instruments. The winners in this environment are issuers with transparent reserves, trust-charter oversight from regulatory bodies such as NYDFS, established banking relationships, proven operational competency and regulatory first distribution strategies. As the data suggests, USDC currently leads the category today, but RLUSD and PYUSD are also purpose-built for this new regime.

Another trend that is driving the adoption of regulated, compliance-first stablecoins is the increasing demand for tokenized treasury yield and other capital markets in North America. North America is leading the global shift toward tokenized financial instruments, particularly: tokenized U.S. treasuries, money market funds, repo markets, corporate credit, commercial paper and private credit and fund structures. Stablecoins serve as the settlement currency for these tokenized assets, replacing legacy payment rails.

This shift is driven by institutional custodians integrating blockchain rails, better regulatory clarity for tokenized funds and the natural alignment of U.S treasuries with USD stablecoins. Stablecoin issuers such as Tether, Circle, and Ripple collectively hold more U.S. treasury bills than all but 13 countries.



Meanwhile, tokenized treasury funds such as Blackrock's BUIDL and VanEck's VBILL benefit from stablecoins being available as an additional offramp with holders being able to instantly exchange their shares for stablecoins including RLUSD.

On a related note, corporate interest in on-chain settlement rails is growing due to their advantages: lower settlement costs, faster international transfers, reduced card-network fees, programmable settlement, and enhanced cross-border remittances. This represents the next major unlock in the institutionalization era, where stablecoins are transitioning from being primarily used by traders to becoming integral to everyday consumer and business payments.

Stablecoins are also rapidly gaining traction in corporate finance as tools for working capital management, cross-border settlement, intraday liquidity, and treasury diversification. Notable adoption examples include multinational payroll operations, global supplier payments, treasury diversification into tokenized T-bills, and cross-entity intercompany transfers.

Regulatory Environment

North America's regulatory environment is the most important factor shaping stablecoin adoption, issuer design and capital flows. Unlike offshore jurisdictions - where stablecoins largely evolved through market-driven dynamics - North America is defining a policy-led market structure. Issuers that align with regulatory expectations gain access to banking relationships, enterprise integrations, and major exchanges, while non-compliant models face exclusion from mainstream financial infrastructure.

United States: Federal and State Frameworks

In July 2025, the U.S. enacted the GENIUS Act, establishing the first comprehensive federal framework for payment stablecoins. The Act authorizes issuance by subsidiaries of insured depository institutions, OCC-approved entities, and issuers operating under qualifying state regimes. Compliant payment stablecoins are explicitly excluded from classification as securities or commodities.

Critically, the GENIUS Act prohibits issuers from offering yield-bearing or interest-generating stablecoins, reinforcing a clear distinction between payment instruments and investment products. By restricting issuers in this manner, the GENIUS Act ensures that stablecoins function as transactional money.

The Act introduces a dual federal-state oversight model, allowing issuers with less than $10B in market capitalization to remain under state supervision, with a transition mechanism as they scale. It also establishes strict reserve standards, requiring 1:1 backing with high-quality liquid assets held in segregated, bankruptcy-remote accounts at U.S. financial institutions. With the GENIUS Act now law, regulatory focus has shifted from legislative debate to implementation by federal and state regulators.

Prior to the enactment of GENIUS, the STABLE Act (Stablecoin Transparency and Accountability for a Better Ledger Economy Act) was another high-profile House proposal but ultimately did not advance. The STABLE Act would have imposed stricter issuer eligibility, narrower reserve requirements, and more punitive disclosure and enforcement provisions - particularly for smaller issuers. Its progression helped shape the debate, but the GENIUS Act ultimately defined a more scalable, bank-integrated framework.

At the state level, the New York Department of Financial Services (NYDFS) remains the most influential stablecoin regulator. Its requirements - full reserve backing, asset segregation, independent attestations, clear redemption rights, and robust operational controls - have effectively become the U.S. compliance benchmark. Stablecoins under NYDFS supervision benefit from enhanced credibility with exchanges, custodians, and institutional counterparties.

Other states are also contributing to regulatory clarity. Texas has incorporated fiat-backed stablecoins into its money transmission framework, emphasizing reserve quality and redemption rights.

Wyoming has positioned itself as a digital asset innovation hub through specialized trust structures and its stablecoin laws center on the Wyoming Stable Token Act (2023), establishing a framework for fully-backed, state-issued stablecoins like the Frontier Stable Token (FRNT). It requires the Trust Account to hold between 100% and 102% backing for all outstanding tokens with reserves limited to highly liquid, low-risk assets and ensure 1:1 redemption for U.S. dollars. In January 2026, Wyoming's stable token FRNT was made available for public purchase through Kraken and is now available on seven blockchains including Ethereum, Solana, Avalanche, Base, Arbitrum, Polygon and Optimism.

Canadian Regulatory Updates

Canada has taken a more cautious, centralized approach, but regulatory clarity is improving. The proposed Stablecoin Act would require issuers to register with the Bank of Canada, maintain 1:1 reserves, provide regular reporting, and hold reserves with qualified custodians in segregated accounts.

Meanwhile, the Ontario Securities Commission (OSC) and the Investment Industry Regulatory Organization of Canada (IIROC) continue to strengthen oversight of platforms offering stablecoins, focusing on disclosure, custody standards, and investor protection - particularly where stablecoins are used in trading or yield-related products.

Across federal, state, and provincial regimes, regulation in the North American region is converging on a consistent model. Regulators favor stablecoins with simple, transparent reserve structures, clear redemption rights, segregated custody, and robust compliance programs, including KYC, AML, and sanctions screening.

Ultimately, North American policy is rewarding institutionally ready, non-yield-bearing stablecoins - those designed to operate safely at scale within existing financial systems. As regulation continues to mature, compliant stablecoins are positioned to capture the majority of regional adoption, while yield-bearing and less aligned models face increasing friction.

Stablecoin Use Cases in North America

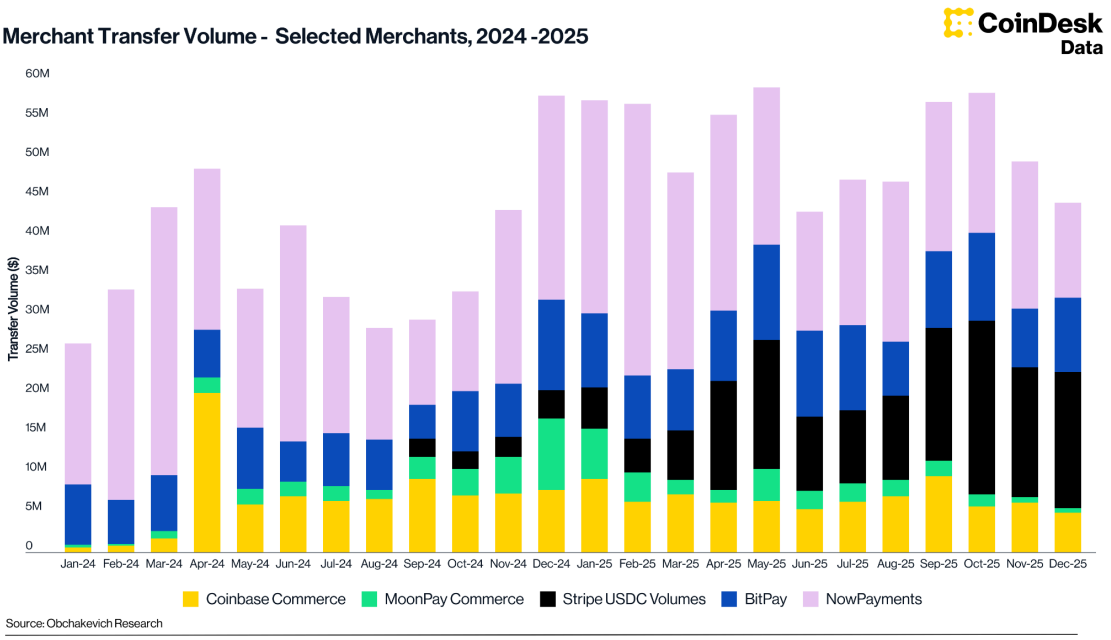
Stablecoin adoption in North America has expanded well beyond its original role as a trading instrument. Today, stablecoins are progressively used as functional financial infrastructure, supporting payments, settlements, capital markets, exchange liquidity and consumer-facing financial products. The region's regulatory clarity and institutional participation have accelerated this shift, positioning stablecoins as a foundational layer for modern financial workflows.

1) Payments and Settlements

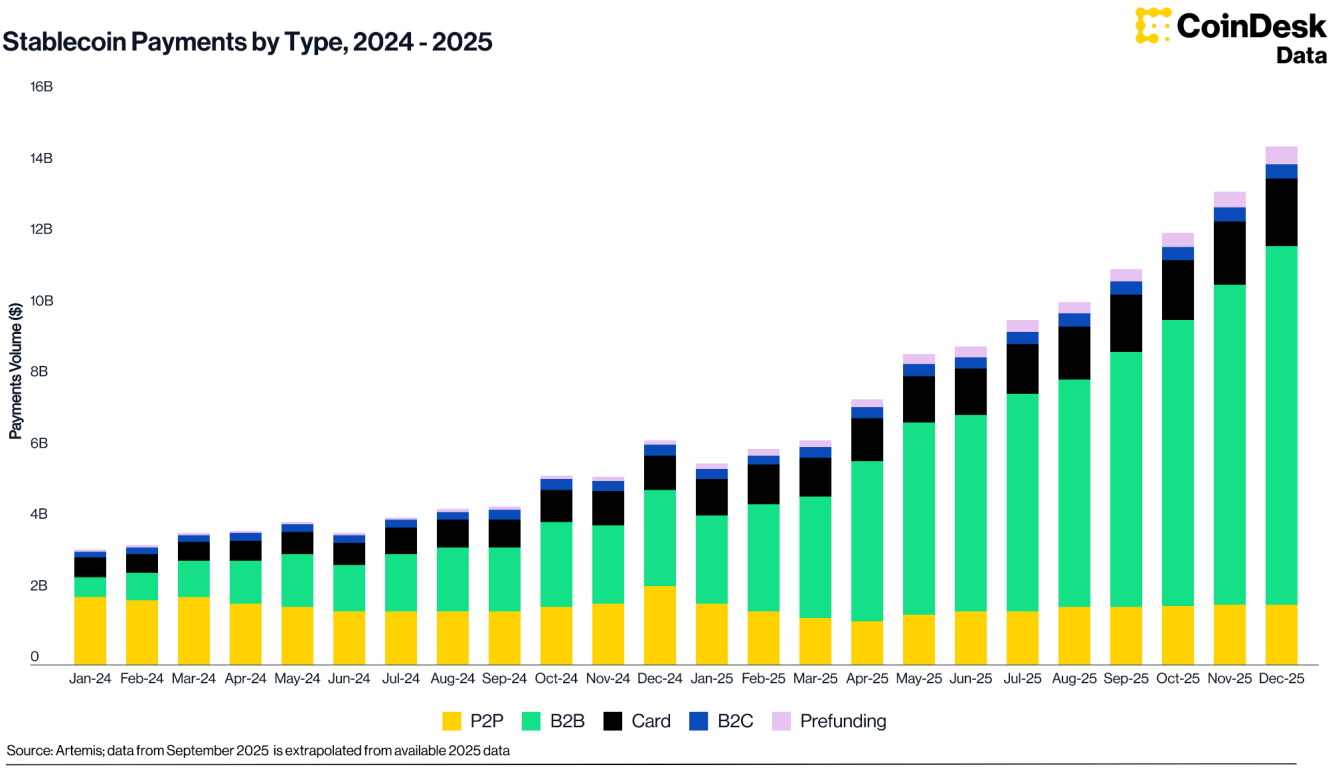
Payments and settlement represent one of the rapidly growing stablecoin use cases in North America. Stablecoins are growingly viewed as a complement or an alternative to traditional payment rails, particularly for use cases where speed, cost efficiency and programmability are critical.

Merchants and payment service providers are adopting stablecoins to reduce settlement times, lower transaction fees, improve reconciliation, and enable 24/7 payment flows. In contrast to card networks and bank transfers, stablecoin settlement occurs near-instantly and does not depend on banking hours. This has made stablecoins attractive for e-commerce platforms, global marketplaces, and digital service providers operating across jurisdictions.

An analysis of stablecoin transfer volumes across selected North America-based merchants and payment processors shows a strong upward trend, with yearly volumes rising 38.0% to $625M.



Cross-border B2B payments continue to represent one of the strongest stablecoin use cases in North America. B2B payments have seen their share of aggregate stablecoin payments rise from 17.4% at the start of 2024 to 62.9%. Stablecoins enable faster international settlement, reduce reliance on correspondent banking networks, and lower foreign exchange and intermediary costs, while improving transparency for corporate treasury teams. As a result, North American enterprises are increasingly leveraging stablecoins for supplier payments, intercompany transfers, and global treasury operations - particularly across corridors connecting the U.S. and Canada with Latin America and Asia.



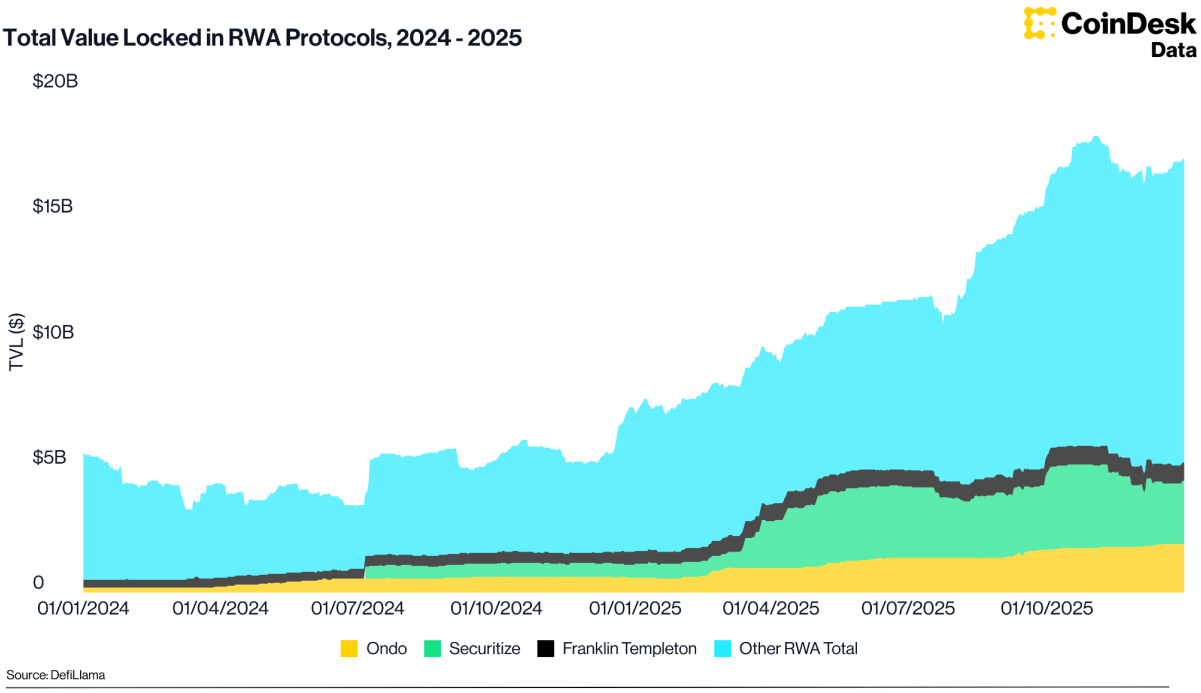
As corporate finance functions become more data-driven and time-sensitive, treasury teams are progressively evaluating stablecoins as an on-chain tool for liquidity and balance sheet optimization. Stablecoins enable near-real-time intraday liquidity management, efficient cross-entity fund movement, and faster settlement of tokenized financial assets, allowing treasurers to reduce idle cash balances and improve capital efficiency. In North America, firms such as JPMorgan (Onyx) and Figure Technologies are piloting stablecoin-based rails for internal fund transfers and on-chain settlement, while platforms like Circle are working with corporate partners to support treasury-grade stablecoin infrastructure.

Beyond core liquidity management, stablecoins provide a foundation for more advanced treasury workflows, including tokenized receivables, programmable escrow arrangements, and automated collateral management. Fintechs and financial institutions such as Visa, Stripe, and PayPal are engaging with stablecoin infrastructure at the treasury level to support short-term cash optimization and settlement of tokenized assets. While adoption remains early, these pilots indicate growing comfort with stablecoins as operational cash instruments and position them as a key component of next-generation, on-chain corporate treasury architecture.

2) On-Chain Capital Markets

North America sits at the forefront of on-chain capital markets, where stablecoins have emerged as the dominant settlement and collateral layer. In 2025, total value locked across real-world asset (RWA) protocols surged by 97.6% to reach $20.8B, underscoring the rapid maturation of the sector.

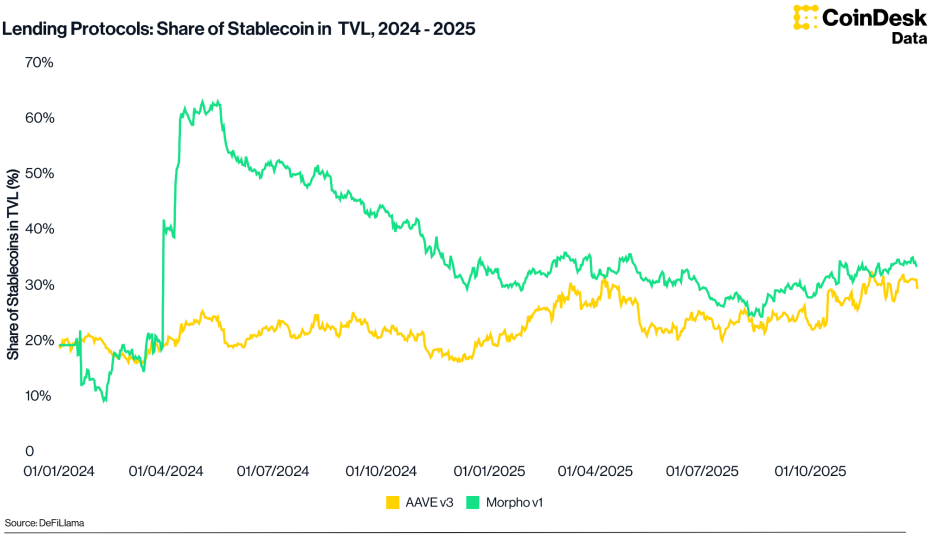
The expansion of tokenized real-world stocks has materially increased demand for stablecoins, which function as the digital cash leg of these markets. Stablecoins are now integral to subscriptions and redemptions, collateral management, and secondary-market settlement.



Adoption of tokenized U.S. Treasury products - such as those issued by Ondo Finance, Securitize, and Franklin Templeton - have seen accelerating adoption. These instruments rely on stablecoins as their default settlement asset, reinforcing the central role of USD-backed tokens as the monetary backbone of on-chain finance.

In on-chain capital markets, stablecoins function as settlement currency for tokenized securities, cash legs for repo-like structures, liquidity instruments for intraday trading, and capital allocation tools for institutional participants. This role mirrors that of cash in traditional markets, but with enhanced programmability and real-time settlement.

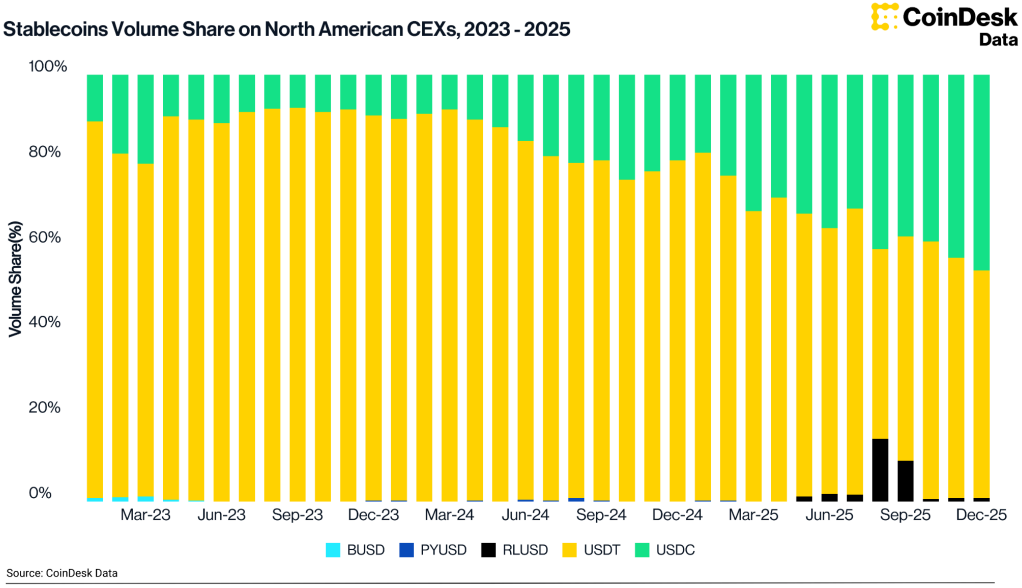
Stablecoins also play a critical role as collateral in both decentralized and institutional lending markets. They are favored due to price stability, high liquidity, transparent backing, and predictable redemption mechanics. An analysis of the collateral composition within the total value locked (TVL) of the two largest lending platforms, Aave and Morpho, shows a significant increase in the share of stablecoins. On Aave, stablecoins rose from 20.5% in 2024 to 30.6% by the end of 2025, while Morpho saw a similar shift, with stablecoins increasing from 20.6% to 34.7% over the same period.



As RWAs expand, stablecoins increasingly sit at the center of lending, leverage, and yield-generation strategies across North American platforms.

3) Exchange & Trading Infrastructure

Exchanges remain a core driver of stablecoin demand, but the structure of trading infrastructure in North America is evolving. North American exchanges are steadily shifting toward USD-denominated trading pairs backed by regulated stablecoins. This reflects regulatory expectations, institutional preference for compliant assets, and reduced reliance on offshore liquidity. A notable structural shift is the emergence of stable base-currency models where a single regulated stablecoin becomes the default quote and settlement asset across an exchange.
Examples include Coinbase's deep integration of USDC as its primary base currency and Gemini's introduction of RLUSD base pairs, positioning RLUSD as a core settlement asset within its ecosystem. These models simplify liquidity positioning, reduce fragmentation, and align exchange operations with regulatory expectations.



An analysis of trading volume shares across North American centralized exchanges shows that USDT continues to dominate, accounting for 53.2% of total stablecoin trading activity. However, USDC's share has surged from 10.4% at the start of 2024 to 45.9%, underscoring a pronounced shift toward regulated stablecoins and away from offshore alternatives in the region.

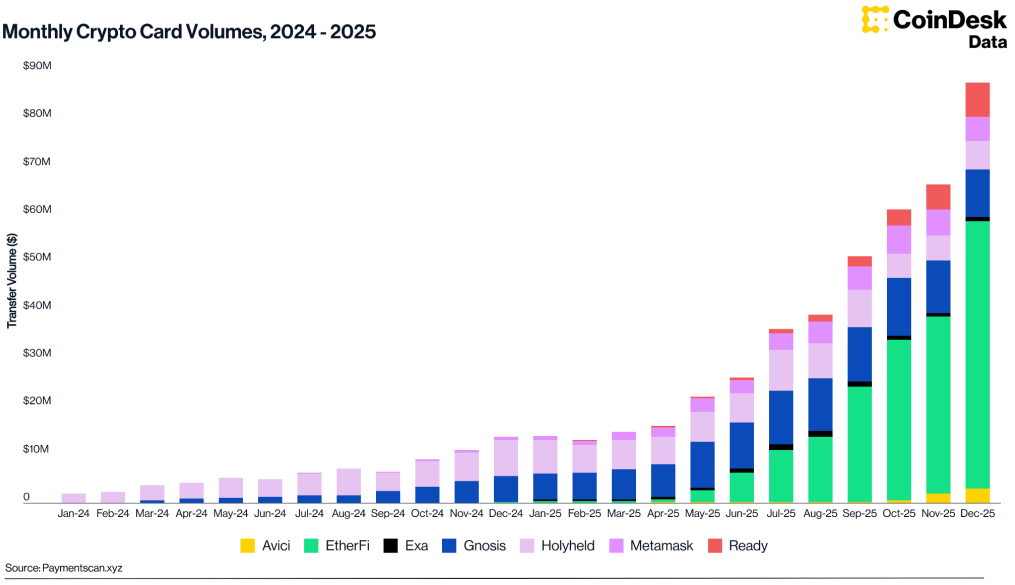
Meanwhile, market makers prefer regulated stablecoins for inventory management, cross-venue settlement, margin posting and capital efficiency. As more North American exchanges standardize around compliant stablecoins, liquidity concentration is expected to increase within a smaller set of trusted issuers.

4) Consumer Adoption

Consumer-facing stablecoin adoption in North America is expanding steadily, driven by improved user experience, regulatory clarity, and integration into familiar financial products.

Stablecoin-enabled wallets and apps such as PayPal and Venmo allow consumers to spend digital dollars, transfer funds globally, and interact with on-chain financial services. These applications abstract blockchain complexity, presenting stablecoins as simple digital cash instruments. Stablecoins are also being incorporated into rewards and loyalty programs, cashback mechanisms, and embedded financial services within consumer platforms. These integrations increase exposure to stablecoins without requiring users to actively engage with crypto markets.

Crypto-linked debit and credit cards represent one of the most visible consumer use cases. These products allow stablecoins to be: spent anywhere traditional cards are accepted, settled on-chain in the background, and integrated into existing payment networks. The monthly crypto card volumes have surged by 533% in 2025, reaching as high as $87.7M in December.



A notable example is the XRP Credit Card in partnership with Mastercard, WebBank and Gemini which supports settlement of credit card transactions over a public blockchain using the RLUSD stablecoin. This highlights how stablecoins are entering everyday consumer financial experiences while maintaining compliance and transparency.

Across payments, capital markets, exchanges and consumer products, stablecoins in North America are increasingly defined by utility rather than speculation. Their role as settlement assets, collateral instruments, and payment rails continues to expand, supported by regulatory clarity and institutional adoption. As these use cases mature, compliant, transparent stablecoins are positioned to capture the majority of the growth - reinforcing North America's role as the leading market for regulated stablecoin innovation.

Liquidity, Markets, and Technical Infrastructure

Liquidity quality and operational infrastructure are critical determinants of stablecoin adoption in North America. Beyond market capitalization, institutions evaluate stablecoins based on depth, resilience, transparency, and settlement reliability. As regulated stablecoins move towards being a core financial infrastructure, these factors have become central to issuer competitiveness and institutional trust.

Liquidity Metrics

Liquidity on centralized exchanges remains the primary access point for stablecoins in North America. For institutions and professional market participants, liquidity is assessed not merely through headline trading volumes, but through deeper structural metrics such as order book resilience, bid-ask spreads, and the capacity to execute large transactions with minimal slippage.

Regulated North American exchanges have increasingly concentrated stablecoin liquidity within a narrow set of compliant issuers, reflecting evolving regulatory expectations and heightened risk management standards. Stablecoins that achieve sustained depth on these venues are consequently better positioned for institutional trading activity, OTC settlement, and treasury management use cases.

At the same time, on-chain liquidity has emerged as an important complement to centralized markets. Stablecoin liquidity pools across major blockchain networks-including Ethereum, Solana, and the XRP Ledger - support a wide range of activities spanning decentralized trading, lending and borrowing, cross-chain settlement, and automated liquidity provisioning. Ethereum continues to dominate as the preferred venue for institutional DeFi participation and real-world asset-related liquidity, while Solana has gained traction as a high-throughput environment optimized for payment-oriented flows. The XRP Ledger remains focused on enterprise-grade settlement, particularly for cross-border transactions. Multi-chain stablecoin availability enables institutions to optimize settlement pathways and dynamically manage liquidity across venues.

Market makers also play a critical role in sustaining stablecoin liquidity and maintaining price stability. In North America, liquidity provision strategies prioritize regulated stablecoins with transparent reserve structures, predictable issuance and redemption mechanisms, and robust custodial frameworks. Assets exhibiting strong peg stability and regulatory clarity attract deeper and more consistent market-making capital. This dynamic has reinforced liquidity concentration around compliance-first stablecoins, while limiting depth for issuers perceived to carry elevated regulatory or structural risk.

Reserve Transparency and Attestations

Stablecoin issuers employ varying methods to demonstrate backing, including third-party attestations, independent audits, real-time or near-real-time reserve disclosures and custodian confirmations. While formats differ, the market has largely converged on independent attestation as the baseline requirement for institutional adoption.

In North America, regulators and institutions strongly prefer stablecoins with segregated reserves, as this reduces counterparty risk, improves bankruptcy protection, and supports reliable redemptions. Stablecoins with commingled reserves face higher barriers to approval by regulated exchanges and payment providers.

Attestation practices are another differentiator. While monthly attestations remain standard, momentum is building toward more frequent reporting, greater transparency on reserve composition, and more granular disclosures. Issuers adopting higher-frequency or enhanced attestations are viewed as better aligned with regulatory and institutional risk management expectations.

For example, Ripple's RLUSD offers near real-time transparency alongside monthly attestations by an independent U.S.-licensed CPA, conducted under AICPA standards. RLUSD is issued through Standard Custody & Trust Company (SCTC), a New York-chartered trust company acting in a fiduciary capacity, and is over-collateralised - providing an additional layer of protection beyond the 1:1 reserve requirement standard across the industry.

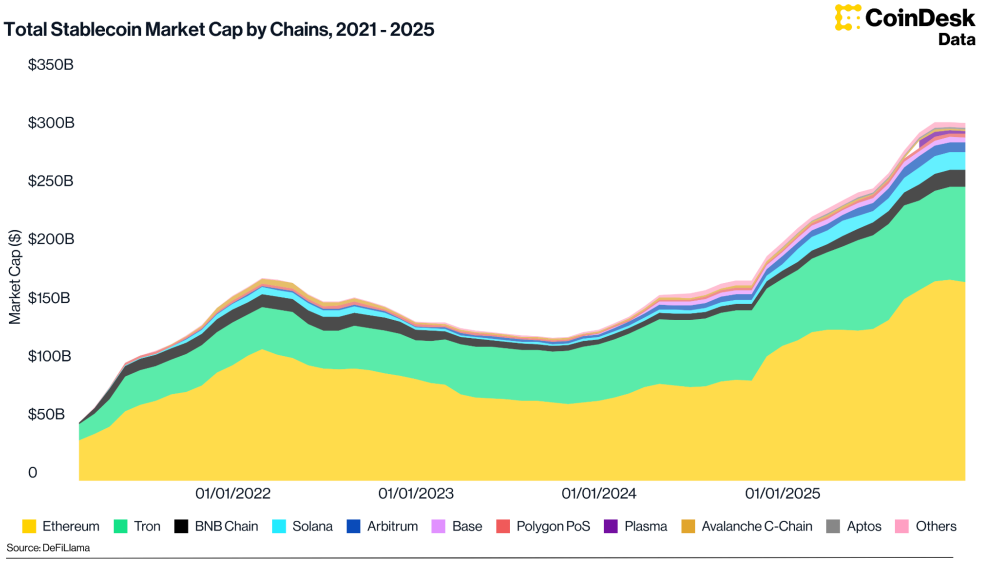
Ultimately, liquidity quality and reserve transparency are now baseline requirements. Stablecoins that pair deep, resilient liquidity with transparent, well-governed reserve structures are best positioned for institutional adoption in North America.

	USDT	USDC	RLUSD	PYUSD
Reporting Cadence	Quarterly Reserve Report + Near real-time dashboard	Monthly Attestation + Near real-time dashboard	Monthly Attestation + Near real-time dashboard	Monthly Attestation
Attested by	BDO	Deloitte	Deloitte	KPMG LLP
Granularity of Reserves Breakdown	Asset category breakdown provided; limited Treasury maturity detail	Detailed asset and U.S. Treasury maturity breakdown	Detailed asset and U.S. Treasury Bills breakdown	Detailed asset and U.S. Treasury Bills breakdown
Reserves Composition	Cash and cash equivalents, short-term deposits, corporate bonds, precious metals, other investments, secured loans	U.S. Treasuries and cash held via Circle Reserve Fund and regulated banks	U.S. Treasury Bills, cash, and government money market funds	U.S. Treasury Bills, repo agreements, cash, and government money market funds
Reserves Custody	Cantor Fitzgerald (U.S. Treasuries); gold reportedly held in Swiss vaults; other custodians not fully disclosed	BNY Mellon (primary custodian); cash also held at regulated financial institutions	BNY Mellon (primary custodian).	Paxos Trust Company
Reserves Management	Managed internally by Tether Limited	Circle Reserve Fund managed by BlackRock	Managed by Standard Custody & Trust Company LLC (Ripple's NYDFS-regulated trust)	Managed by Paxos Trust Company

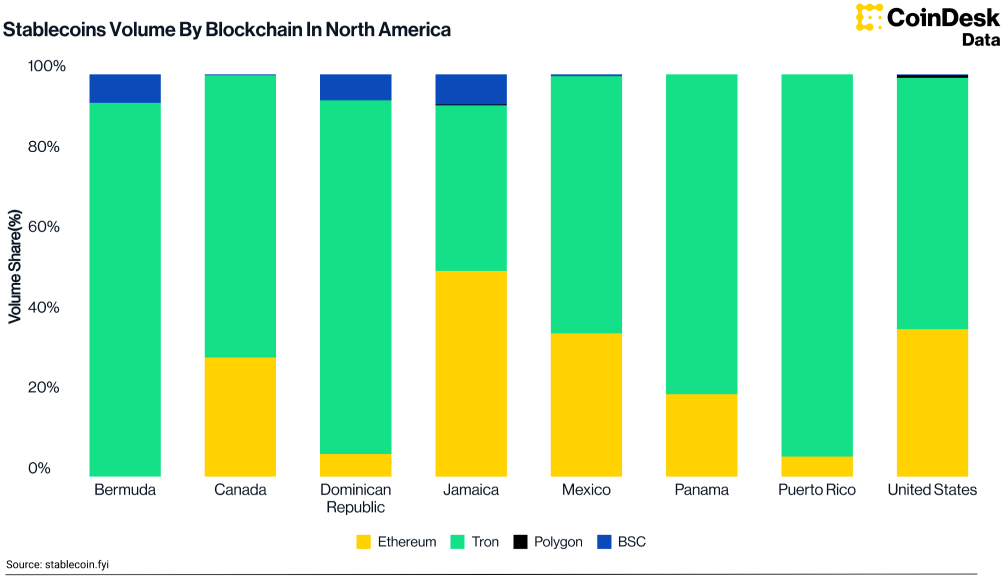
Chain Distribution

Chain distribution is a critical component of stablecoin market structure in North America. As stablecoins increasingly function as settlement assets rather than speculative instruments, market structure depends not only on the issuer, but also where and how stablecoins circulate across blockchain networks.

Ethereum remains the primary settlement layer for stablecoins, particularly for institutional DeFi, tokenized RWAs, on-chain capital markets, and high-value settlement flows. Its role as the foundational smart contract platform continues to attract stablecoin issuance despite higher transaction costs. At the end of 2025, Ethereum hosts 55.4% of all stablecoin supply highlighting its dominance in the sector.



Meanwhile, Tron remains a key hub for stablecoin activity, driven by strong usage in emerging markets and deep integration with centralized exchanges. Its low fees and fast settlement make it well suited for everyday stablecoin transfers, particularly in regions facing currency volatility. Supported by large exchange balances and transfer flows, Tron is the second-largest blockchain by stablecoin supply while being the leading chain by transaction volume, reinforcing its role as a core settlement layer in North American countries.



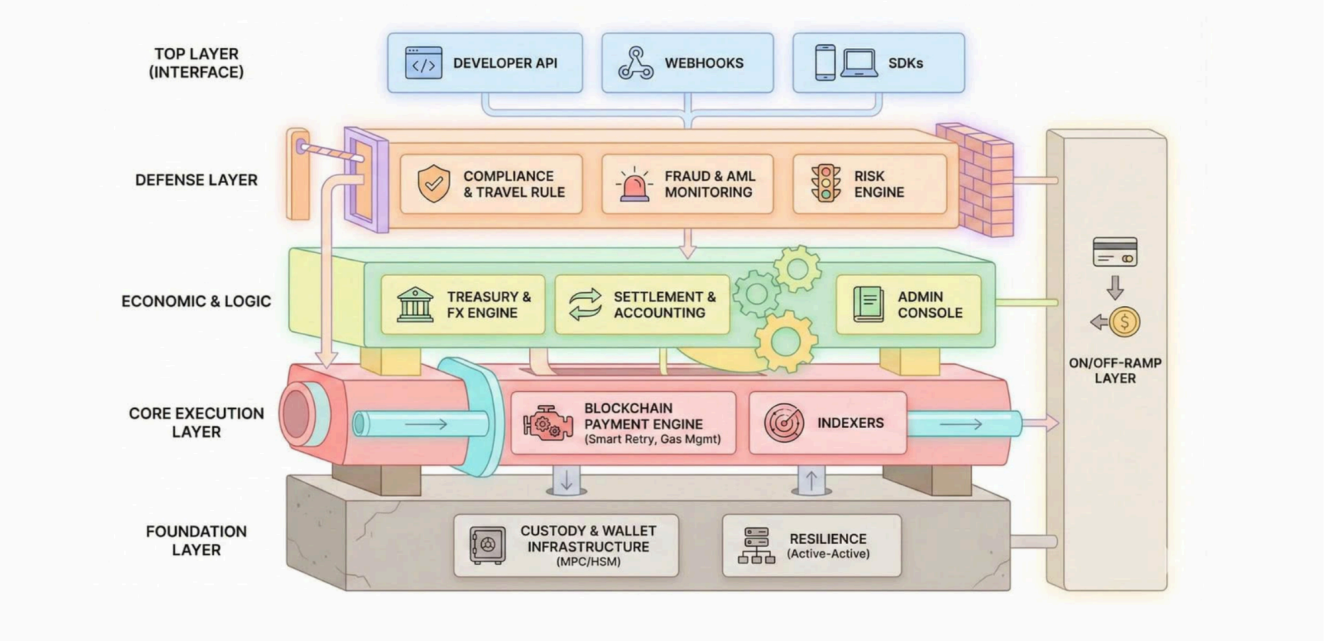
A defining trend in North America is the rise of multi-chain stablecoin portfolios for institutional settlement. Rather than concentrating liquidity on a single network, institutions are distributing stablecoin balances across multiple chains to optimize settlement routes, manage operational risk, reduce reliance on any one network, and enhance capital efficiency. Reflecting this shift, stablecoins such as RLUSD have announced plans to expand beyond their current deployments on Ethereum and XRPL to additional networks, including Ethereum Layer-2s, further supporting more flexible and resilient settlement infrastructure.

For North American institutions, this flexibility is essential. It allows stablecoins to function as a unified settlement layer across fragmented blockchain ecosystems while maintaining compliance, transparency and operational resilience.

Infrastructure Readiness for Institutions

Architecture of Institutional Stablecoin Rails

CoinDesk Data



Source: Fystack.io

For stablecoins to function as core financial infrastructure in North America, they must be supported by robust institutional-grade systems. Beyond regulatory compliance and liquidity, adoption depends on the availability of operational, technical and governance infrastructure that integrates seamlessly with existing financial workflows. North America has emerged as the global leader in institutional stablecoin infrastructure, driven by advances in compliance tooling, standardized APIs, and regulated custody solutions.

Institutional adoption of stablecoins is contingent on strong compliance frameworks. Stablecoins operating in North America are embedded within compliance rails that mirror traditional financial standards. These rails typically include Know Your Customer (KYC) onboarding process, Anti-Money Laundering (AML) and Counter-Terrorist Financing (CTF) controls, sanctions screening and transaction monitoring, audit trails and reporting systems compatible with regulatory oversight. On-chain analytics and compliance platforms have become deeply embedded in stablecoin ecosystems, enabling institutions to monitor transaction activity in real time. For example, RLUSD integrates directly with leading providers such as Chainalysis and TRM Labs through API-based tooling, delivering

continuous transaction monitoring, risk assessment, and compliance oversight. This reduces operational risk and enables stablecoins to be used confidently within regulated financial environments.

Another critical component of infrastructure readiness is the adoption of standardized, API-driven integration models, similar to those mandated under Europe's PSD2 open banking framework. In the North American landscape, this manifests through programmable payment APIs, real-time balance and transaction reporting, automated reconciliation tools, integration with treasury management systems and ERP platforms. These APIs enable stablecoins to be embedded directly into enterprise workflows, supporting use cases such as automated payments and settlements, treasury rebalancing, liquidity routing across chains and venues, and integration with FinTech and banking systems. As stablecoins interact with both on-chain and off-chain systems, API standardization is becoming a prerequisite for scale.

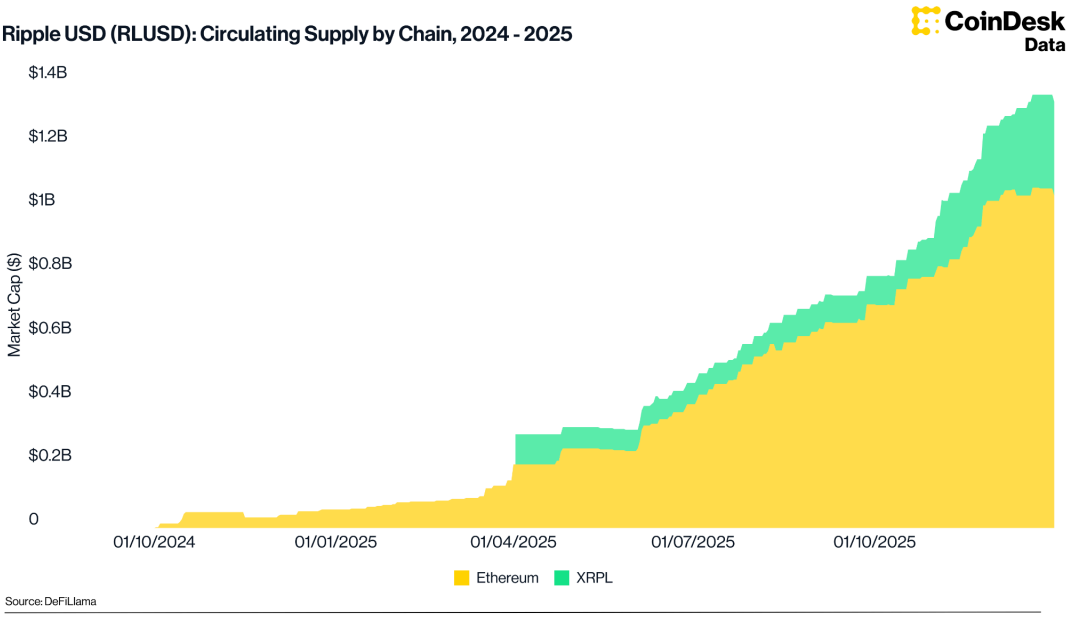
Meanwhile, custody remains one of the most critical factors for institutional participation. Many institutions are prohibited from self-custodying digital assets, making regulated custodians essential for stablecoin adoption. North American custody infrastructure has matured significantly with providers such as BitGo, Gemini Custody, Anchorage Digital, Fireblocks offering secure storage, transaction authorization and policy controls tailored to institutional requirements. These custodians support segregation of client assets, multi-party computation (MPC) or cold storage solutions, insurance coverage, integration with compliance and reporting tools and connectivity to exchanges, OTC desks and payment networks. Custody support enables stablecoins to be used in treasury operations, fund management, and institutional settlement workflows, bridging the gap between blockchain-native assets and traditional finance institutions.

Institutions also evaluate stablecoin infrastructure based on system uptime, and reliability, redundancy across service providers, disaster recovery and business continuity planning and the ability to scale transaction volumes without degradation. North America's stablecoin infrastructure has progressed to meet these standards, reflecting the growing convergence between digital asset systems and traditional finance market infrastructure.

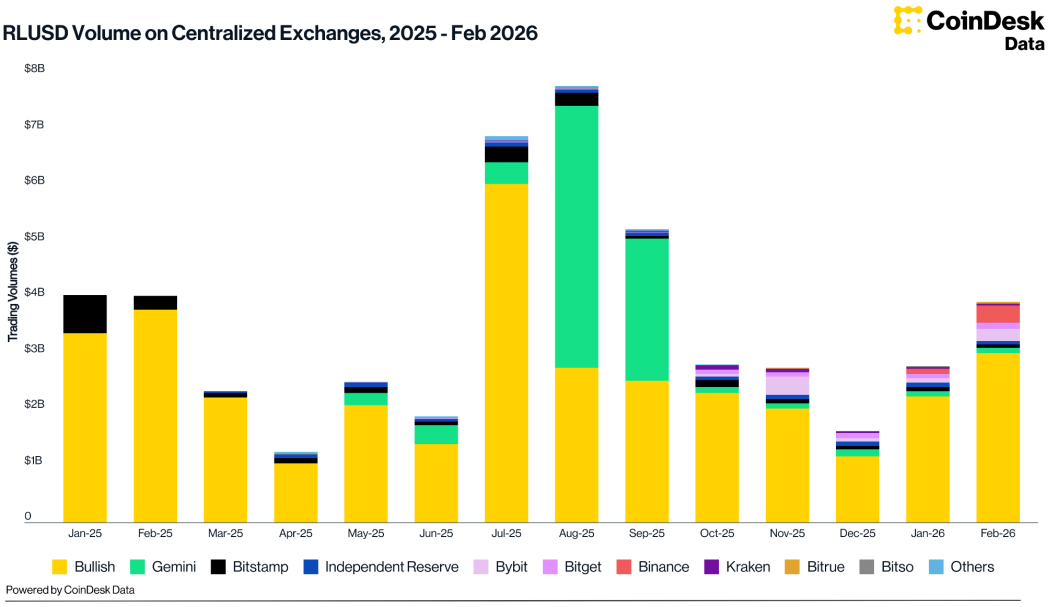
RLUSD: A Case Study Inside the North American Stablecoin Market

Ripple USD (RLUSD) is a U.S dollar-backed stablecoin issued by Ripple via its subsidiary Standard Custody & Trust Company LLC. It is a fully reserved stablecoin that is designed to operate within regulated financial environments with reserves held in high-quality, liquid assets and managed under governance and transparency frameworks consistent with U.S. regulatory expectations.

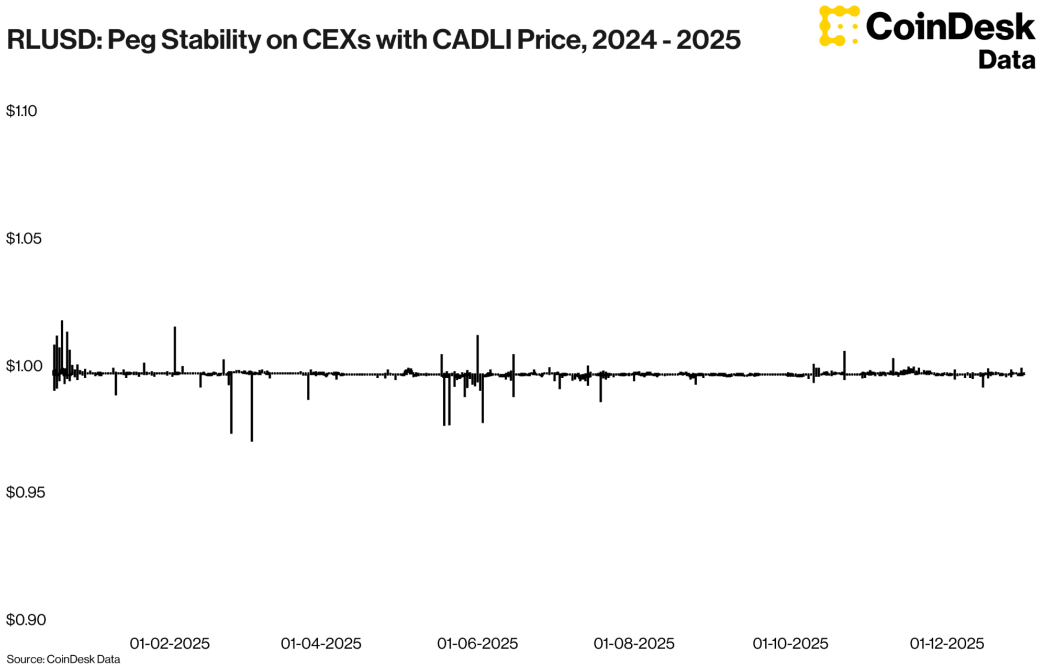
Unlike earlier generations of stablecoins that gained adoption primarily through offshore trading venues or crypto native applications, RLUSD entered the market with a compliance-first and institution-oriented design. Its primary objective is to function as a reliable digital dollar targeting institutions and enterprises with use cases like cross-border payments, on-chain treasury, and merchant settlements - with Ripple actively looking to expand into additional verticals such as capital markets, trade finance, and broader institutional workflows.



Within a year of launch, the stablecoin has surpassed over $1B in market capitalization highlighting the demand for the stablecoin. The stablecoin has a circulating supply of $1.34B at the end of 2025, issued natively on XRPL and Ethereum. 80% of the circulating supply is currently on Ethereum while the rest is on XRPL. Ripple has announced its plan to expand the stablecoin across several Ethereum Layer-2s including Optimism, Kraken's Ink, Uniswap's Unichain and the XRPL next year. The integration will be executed using interoperability protocol Wormhole's cross-chain tech for native transfers.



The stablecoin is also listed on over 10 major centralized exchanges including Binance, Kraken, Bybit, Bullish and Bitget. RLUSD was the fourth largest stablecoin by trading volumes on centralized exchanges, trading $43.3B in 2025. Bullish was the leading exchange in terms of RLUSD trading volumes on centralized exchanges, trading $30.8B in 2025. Gemini and Bitstamp were the next leading venues for RLUSD trading with volumes surpassing $8.49B and $2.06B respectively. Outside of crypto centralized exchanges, RLUSD is available for purchase on on/off ramps including Transak and MoonPay.



RLUSD's initial liquidity has formed primarily on regulated exchanges rather than unregulated ones - a meaningful distinction in a landscape where many offshore venues also carry regulatory licenses - reflecting a deliberate focus on compliance and credibility over speculative growth. Early trading shows orderly issuance and redemption, stable peg performance, and measured liquidity provisioning. Since launch, RLUSD has consistently maintained parity with its peg across all exchanges, highlighting robust liquidity and a well-functioning issuance and redemption mechanism.

A key milestone was RLUSD's introduction as an optional base currency for all spot trading pairs available to Gemini users in the United States, streamlining transfers by removing additional conversion steps and associated fees. In January 2026, Ripple announced a partnership with LMAX Group to integrate RLUSD across the exchange's global marketplace as a core collateral asset within its institutional trading infrastructure. This integration will enable enhanced cross-collateralisation and margin efficiencies across spot crypto, perpetual futures, and CFD trading.

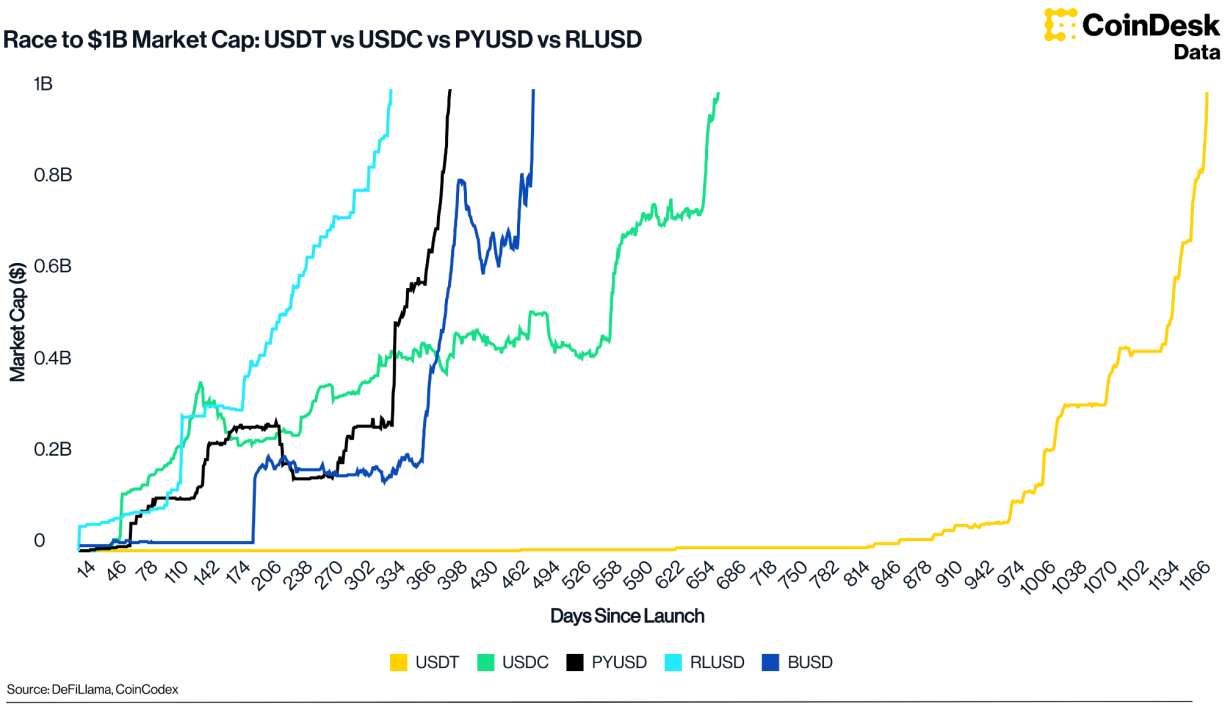
Beyond exchange activity, RLUSD has entered pilot programs with fintechs and payment service providers (PSPs). For example, RLUSD is being used in a pilot program involving Ripple, Mastercard, WebBank, and Gemini to explore stablecoin-based settlement of credit card transactions on the XRP Ledger. As the issuer of the Gemini Credit Card, WebBank is evaluating the use of RLUSD to settle Mastercard transactions on XRPL. If successful, this would mark one of the first cases of a regulated U.S. bank settling traditional card payments using a regulated stablecoin on a public blockchain. The pilot highlights the potential to replace slow, costly settlement rails, enabling near-instant settlement - particularly for cross-border transactions - rather than the typical one-to-three-day clearing period.

Meanwhile, a key differentiator in RLUSD's early adoption is its integration with Ripple Payments. This integration allows RLUSD to support cross-border payment flows already supported by Ripple's network functioning as an on-ramp, off-ramp or bridge asset. Rather than creating new distribution from scratch, RLUSD leverages existing financial institution relationships, established payment corridors and operational workflows already in production. This reduces adoption friction and anchors RLUSD usage in real transactional demand, particularly for enterprise and PSP-driven settlement flows.

Why RLUSD Fits North American Market Needs

The North American stablecoin market is largely defined by growing regulatory scrutiny, institutional participation, and integration with existing financial infrastructure. In this environment, adoption is driven less by scale at launch and more by compliance posture, operational credibility, and infrastructure compatibility. RLUSD aligns closely with these requirements, making it a relevant case study of how stablecoins are evolving in that region.

One of the most important factors shaping stablecoin adoption in North America is regulatory alignment. RLUSD enters the market with a clear compliance posture designed to meet emerging expectations around reserve transparency, segregation of assets, governance controls, and regulated issuance and redemption processes. This approach aligns with guidance from U.S. federal agencies, state-level supervisors, and Canadian regulators, all of whom have emphasized the importance of stablecoin operating as reliable, fully-backed representations of fiat currency. By prioritizing regulatory-grade design from inception, RLUSD reduces uncertainty for exchanges, custodians, and institutional users evaluating its suitability for production use. RLUSD reached the $1B landmark in just 323 days since its official launch on December 17th 2024, faster than other stablecoins when compared with USDT, USDC and PYUSD.



In a market where adoption is heavily influenced by issuer credibility. RLUSD benefits from being issued by Ripple, a firm with long-standing relationships across banks, payment service providers and financial institutions globally. Unlike issuers whose presence is primarily crypto-native, Ripple's core business has historically focused on cross-border payments, enterprise settlement systems, and integration with regulation financial entities. This background matters in North America where institutions assess stablecoins not only on technical design, but also on the issuer's operational track record, governance maturity, and ability to support mission-critical financial workflows. RLUSD's association with an established financial infrastructure provider lowers adoption friction for institutions that require vendor credibility and long-term operational support.

A defining feature of stablecoin adoption in North America is the need to bridge on-chain markets with traditional financial infrastructure. RLUSD is positioned to operate seamlessly across both. On-chain, it circulates across multiple blockchain networks, supporting exchange trading and settlement, decentralized liquidity and lending, and interaction with tokenized assets. Off-chain, RLUSD integrates with traditional financial rails via payment systems, custody providers, and enterprise APIs.

This dual compatibility enables RLUSD to function as a settlement asset for on-chain capital markets, a liquidity instrument for exchanges and OTC desks, and a USD representation within enterprise payment and treasury workflows. Its strategic value is further enhanced by Ripple's recent acquisitions, which have expanded the firm's capabilities across payments, custody, prime brokerage, corporate treasury management and stablecoin infrastructure. Notably, through its acquisition of Hidden Road, Ripple has become one of the few crypto-native, non-bank institutions to own and operate a global prime broker. Now rebranded as Ripple Prime, **the platform processes approximately $3T annually, handles $10B in daily volume, and facilitates 50M transactions each day** - creating a clear pathway for RLUSD to integrate seamlessly into a comprehensive institutional financial stack. Similarly, **GTreasury - now Ripple Treasury - reportedly orchestrated about $13T in payments last year**, creating another potential avenue for RLUSD adoption in enterprise treasury operations.

Acquired Entity	Pillar	Estimated Acquisition Value	Date	Impact/Scale
Hidden Road	Prime Brokerage	$1.25B	Apr 2025	Clears $3T annually, 300+ institutional clients
GTreasury	Treasury Management	$1.0B	Oct 2025	Integrates with Fortune 500; manages trillions in volume
Metaco	Custody	$250M	May 2023	Institutional Digital Asset Custody
Rail	Stablecoin and Payment Infrastructure	$200M	Aug 2025	Enterprise-grade stablecoin payments with integration into card networks, ACH, and domestic instant-payment workflows
Palisade	Wallet Infrastructure	N/A	Nov 2025	Lightweight, high-speed wallet-as-a-service platform complementing Ripple Custody

With its recent acquisitions and expanded product suite, Ripple Payments operates as a unified financial infrastructure solution designed to support the entire lifecycle of global money movement. Rather than stitching together multiple vendors for collections, custody, liquidity, compliance, and payouts across different geographies, Ripple Payments provides a single integrated infrastructure layer that enables businesses to collect, hold, exchange, and move value across fiat and digital asset networks.

A typical payments lifecycle begins when a user or business initiates a transaction. Ripple Payments provides APIs and infrastructure that allow enterprises, fintechs, and financial institutions to integrate global payment capabilities directly into their systems and initiate cross-border transfers. Once a payment request is initiated, funds are first collected from

the sender. Ripple Payments now seamlessly supports multiple collection methods including local bank transfers, instant payment rails, and stablecoin transfers across multiple jurisdictions through its acquisition of Rail.

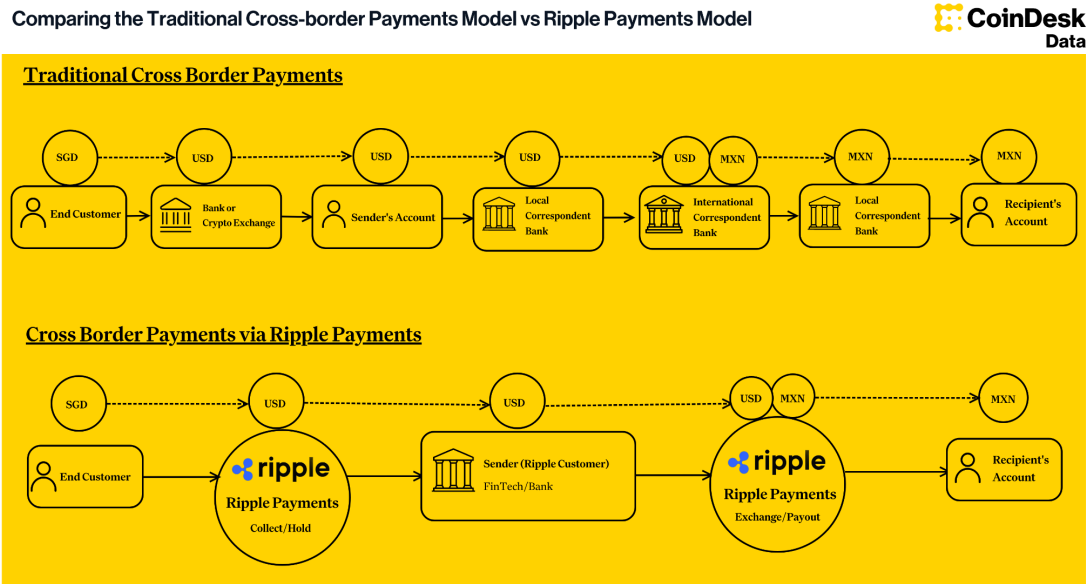
Stablecoin funds can also be received directly into blockchain wallets managed through Ripple's custody infrastructure, which has been significantly strengthened through the acquisitions of Metaco and Palisade. These capabilities enable institutions to securely provision wallets, manage private keys, and hold digital assets at scale.

Once funds are available, they can be exchanged and routed through Ripple Payments' liquidity and conversion infrastructure, enabling businesses to move value efficiently across different currencies and asset types. The platform supports both fiat and stablecoin transactions, allowing enterprises to manage liquidity and execute cross-border payments without relying on fragmented external providers.

Before funds move, Ripple's compliance-first infrastructure ensures that transactions undergo rigorous regulatory checks. These include KYC/KYB verification, AML screening, sanctions checks, transaction monitoring, and wallet risk analysis, supported through integrations with leading compliance providers such as Chainalysis and TRM Labs. Underpinning this compliance infrastructure is Ripple's regulatory footprint, which spans over 70 licences globally. Notably, RLUSD is issued through Standard Custody & Trust Company (SCTC), a New York-chartered trust company - a distinct regulatory model from the Money Transmitter Licence (MTL) framework under which competitors such as Circle operate.

Once compliance checks are completed, payments can be processed and routed to the recipient. Ripple Payments coordinates the movement of funds across more than 50 real-time payment rails and partner networks, enabling businesses to send payouts across more than 60 markets.

Settlement can occur across both traditional and blockchain-based payment rails, depending on the payment route and asset used. After settlement is completed, funds are delivered through Ripple's global payout network, allowing recipients to receive funds in the format that best suits their needs - whether as fiat deposited into a bank account or as digital assets transferred to a wallet.



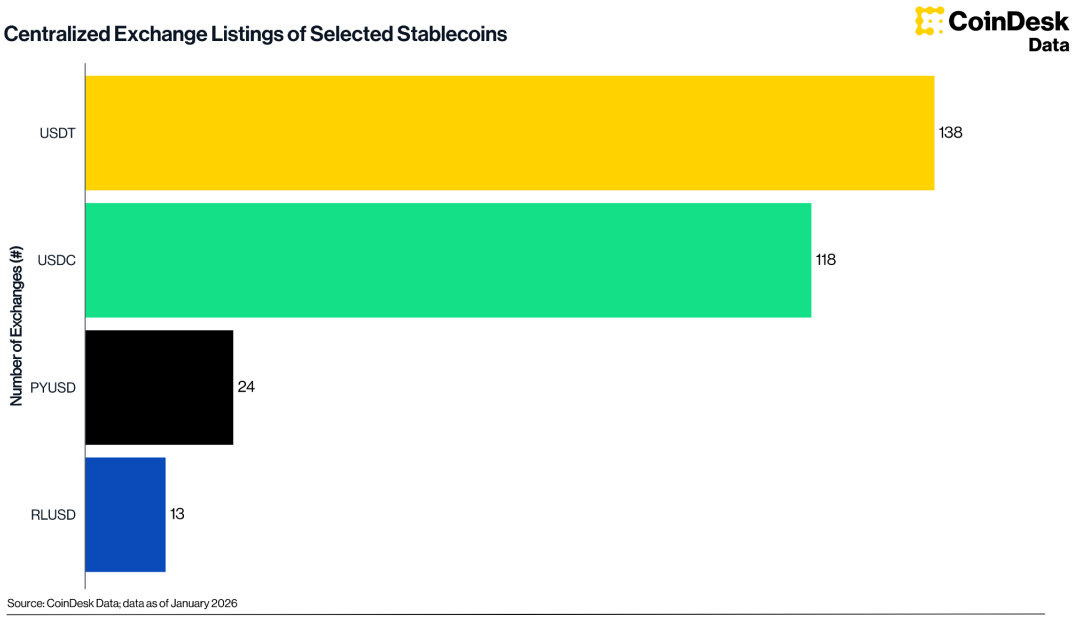
Through an integrated stack spanning collections, custody, liquidity, orchestration, and settlement, Ripple is building a unified payments infrastructure designed to move value globally across both traditional and digital financial rails. Where cross-border payments once required a complex chain of intermediaries - sender banks, correspondent banks, FX providers, settlement networks, and receiving banks - Ripple's architecture collapses this process into a simplified flow: sender, the Ripple's payments infrastructure, and recipient.

Risks & Challenges

While RLUSD demonstrates strong alignment with North American regulatory and institutional requirements, it faces several risks and challenges that are typical for newly launched, compliance-first stablecoins. These risks are primarily related to market structure and adoption dynamics rather than fundamental design flaws.

One of the immediate challenges for RLUSD is that its liquidity remains in an early stage of development. Compared with established stablecoins like USDC and USDT, RLUSD currently exhibits lower aggregate trading volume, shallower order book depth on exchanges and limited on-chain liquidity pools across certain networks. For institutional users, liquidity depth is critical - not only for trading, but also for treasury operations, OTC settlement, and large-value transfers. While RLUSD's liquidity profile is consistent with an institution-first rollout, scaling depth across centralized and decentralized venues will be essential to support broader adoption. Liquidity development is typically a function of time, market-marker participation, and exchange distribution. However, until deeper liquidity is established, some institutions may limit usage to pilot programs or low-volume transactions.

RLUSD enters a market already dominated by well-established compliance-first stablecoins, particularly USDC and PYUSD. These competitors benefit from extensive exchange listings, deep and mature liquidity, strong brand recognition, and entrenched integration across trading, payments and DeFi platforms. USDC, in particular, has become the default stablecoin for institutional trading and on-chain capital markets, while PYUSD benefits from embedded distribution through consumer fintech platforms. To gain market share, RLUSD must demonstrate clear value in specific use cases such as enterprise settlement and cross-border payments - rather than attempting to compete broadly across all segments. Without differentiation, switching costs and network effects favor incumbent stablecoins.



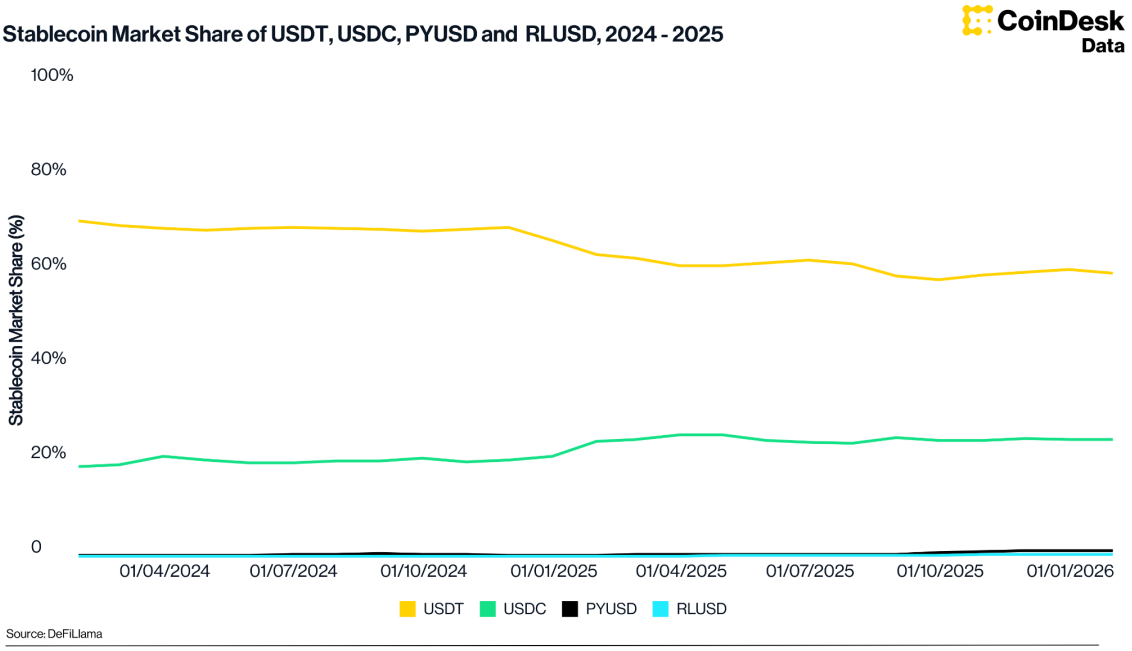
Exchange availability remains a key driver of stablecoin adoption. While RLUSD has secured meaningful early integrations, including base-pair status on regulated exchanges like Gemini, broader distribution across additional North American venues will be necessary to deepen liquidity, attract market markets, and support price discovery. Limited exchange coverage can constrain access for traders, institutions, and liquidity providers, slowing adoption even when underlying infrastructure is sound. Expanding listings while maintaining regulatory alignment will be an important balancing act for RLUSD's growth strategy.

Strategic Outlook for Stablecoins in North America (Next 2-3 Quarters)

The North American stablecoin market is entering a decisive phase of maturation. Regulatory clarity is improving, institutional adoption is accelerating, and stablecoins are increasingly embedded into real economic and financial workflows. Over the next several quarters, growth is expected to be driven more by structural integration into payments, treasury management, and capital markets.

Market Predictions

The most significant trend over the near to medium term is continued growth in regulated, compliance-first stablecoins. As U.S. and Canadian regulators converge on clearer expectations around reserve backing, attestations, and governance, capital and liquidity are concentrated in issuers that meet these standards. Unregulated or opaque stablecoin models are likely to face growing friction in North America, including limiting exchange access, reduced banking relationships, and higher compliance costs. In contrast, stablecoins designed to operate within regulatory frameworks are expected to capture the majority of incremental growth. Alluding to this trend the market dominance of USDT has dropped from 71.1% at the start of 2024 to 59.9% by the end of 2025. Meanwhile, the market share of USDC has risen from 18.4% to 24.7% in the same period. Similarly, regulated stablecoins like PYUSD and RLUSD have entered the top 10 stablecoins and surpassed $1B in market cap faster than both USDT and USDC.



Corporate treasury adoption represents a major unlock for stablecoin demand. Over the next several quarters, more corporations are expected to experiment with stablecoins for internal cash management, use tokenized cash instruments for short-term liquidity and interact with tokenized money market and treasury products. Tokenized

cash and treasury instruments offer corporations improved liquidity visibility, faster settlement, and enhanced capital efficiency. Stablecoins serve as the settlement and liquidity layer for these products, positioning them at the center of emerging corporate finance workflows.

As regulatory and operational requirements increase, the North American stablecoin market is likely to consolidate around a small number of issuers. Compliance costs, licensing complexity, and infrastructure demands create high barriers to entry. This consolidation is expected to result in fewer but larger regulated issuers, clearer segmentation by use case, and reduced fragmentation across liquidity pools. Rather than a single dominant issuer, the market is likely to support several large, trusted stablecoins optimized for different segments of the financial system.

Another key growth area is the expansion of stablecoin-settled credit and lending infrastructure. Stablecoins are increasingly used as collateral in lending markets, settlement assets for on-chain credit products, and liquidity instruments for private credit and structured finance. As tokenized credit markets develop, stablecoins are expected to function as the primary medium for funding. Margining and settlement - mirroring the role of cash in traditional credit markets.

Key Risks

Despite progress, legislative uncertainty remains a central risk. Delays or fragmentation in the implementation of the U.S federal stablecoin legislation could slow institutional adoption, increase compliance complexity and create uneven regulatory treatment across issuers.

Meanwhile, stablecoin issuers remain dependent on access to the traditional banking system for reserve custody, issuance, and redemption. Any tightening of bank-stablecoin relationships - whether due to regulatory pressure or risk aversion - could disrupt issuance and liquidity. Maintaining durable banking partnerships will be critical for stablecoins operating in North America.

Moreover, the proliferation of new Layer 1s and Layer 2s including the new stablecoin focused chains introduces operational complexity. Fragmented liquidity across chains can reduce capital efficiency, complicate compliance monitoring and increase operational risk for institutions. While multi-chain strategies offer flexibility, excessive fragmentation may slow adoption among more conservative institutional participants.

What to Watch

A key indicator to watch will be the pace and breadth of RLUSD's distribution expansion. New exchange listings, improving liquidity depth, and wider adoption by institutional participants would point to growing acceptance within the regulated stablecoin segment. After adding more than $1B in market capitalization in 2025, a comparable increase in circulating supply - measured in USD terms - would propel RLUSD's market cap beyond $2.5B in 2026.

Meanwhile, developments in U.S. Federal stablecoin law will materially influence market structure. Clear legislation could accelerate institutional adoption, while prolonged uncertainty may favor established stablecoins with existing regulatory relationships. As of the most recent legislative drafting in early 2026, the CLARITY Act's provisions on stablecoin yield are still unsettled and actively being negotiated. A prohibition on passive yield for stablecoin holdings is likely to be beneficial for payment-focused stablecoins like RLUSD.

Banks are increasingly exploring tokenized deposit products as complements to stablecoins. In November, J.P. Morgan issued JPM Coin (JPMD), a deposit token deployed on Ethereum Layer 2 Base, enabling near-instant, 24/7 settlement and real-time liquidity management. The interaction between bank-issued deposit tokens and stablecoins is likely to play a defining role in shaping future settlement and liquidity frameworks, particularly for wholesale and corporate use cases.

A parallel trend to watch is the acceleration of tokenization initiatives by large asset managers- especially across money market funds, U.S. Treasuries, and private credit. These efforts are emerging as a key source of structural demand for stablecoins, which increasingly function as on-chain settlement and liquidity rails. A notable example is Ondo Finance's OUSG, where subscriptions and redemptions are settled using RLUSD.

Conclusion

North America continues to solidify its position as the global center of regulated stablecoin innovation. While stablecoins remain a worldwide phenomenon, North American jurisdictions - particularly the United States - are increasingly setting the standards for how stablecoins can operate at scale. This approach emphasizes transparency, governance, and institutional readiness over rapid, speculative growth.

The market is undergoing a clear transition from speculation toward utility-driven adoption. Stablecoins are now being deployed across payments, settlement, corporate treasury operations, and on-chain capital markets, underscoring growing confidence in their role as foundational financial infrastructure rather than purely trading instruments.

This evolution is closely linked to expanding regulatory clarity and accelerating product adoption. Stablecoins that meet institutional expectations around reserve backing, independent attestations, custody standards, and regulatory compliance are gaining access to deeper liquidity, broader distribution channels, and increased institutional participation.

Within this environment, RLUSD fits squarely within the compliance-first stablecoin category, aligning with prevailing market dynamics rather than diverging from them. Its positioning illustrates how new stablecoins can successfully enter the North American market by prioritizing regulatory alignment, infrastructure readiness, and real-world utility from the outset.

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